DMV Tyrant

By Christopher Durang

Scene: A window at the Division of Motor Vehicles. A woman at a window is approached by a customer.

INTRODUCTION

Probably the most frightening phrase you can hear at the DMV is, "It's a clerical error." This phrase can mean almost any imaginable horrible thing you can conjure up. It can mean that you'll have to come back and waste another day. It can mean that you'll have to retake the road test you already passed because your records have been misplaced. Or it can mean that due to a misspelling of your name, you're now on the FBI's most wanted list. And it's not even proper decorum to get angry about such things. You see, it's not really their fault — making errors is part of the system. DMV Tyrant by Christopher Durang

CUSTOMER: Is this window 7?

DMV LADY: Yes?

CUSTOMER: I'm afraid something rather complicated has happened with my driver's license.

DMV LADY: I'm sorry to hear that. What happened? *(With great disinterest he/she begins to read a book).*

CUSTOMER: Well, you see, I moved here from another state, and I let my driver's license lapse . . . and . . . . *(Waits).*

DMV LADY: *(Looks up)* Yes?

CUSTOMER: Should I wait until you finish?

DMV LADY: I don't think so. It's a very long book,

CUSTOMER: But . . . are you listening to my problem?

DMV LADY: I can read and listen at the same time. Go on. *(Goes back to reading).*

CUSTOMER: Oh. Well. Uh, anyway, I took the driving test again, and I passed it and got this temporary license, which has now expired, and I've never gotten my permanent one, and when I called about it, they said they had lost me in the

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computer, and they had no record of my taking the test, and so they couldn't send me my license even though I did take and pass the test. *(Pause)* Your turn to say something.

DMV LADY: Wait a minute. *(Reads some more. Looks up.)* I wanted to finish the paragraph. Now what seems to be the matter?

CUSTOMER: Well . . .

DMV LADY: In one sentence.

CUSTOMER: I haven't received my driver's license.

DMV LADY: Let me see if you're on the computer.

CUSTOMER: I'm not on the computer.

DMV LADY: What is your name?

CUSTOMER: I'm not there.

DMV LADY: How do you spell that?

CUSTOMER: I'm not on the computer. I went to Window 3 and they told me there was no record of me on the computer.

DMV LADY: I am not Window 3, I am Window 7, and I need to know your name.

CUSTOMER: James Agnes.

DMV LADY: Is that A as in aardvark, g as in gesundheit, n as in nincompoop, e as in excruciating, s as in seltzer water, pause pause, j as in Jupiter, a as in Agnes, m as in Mary, e as in excruciating, and s as in slow, lingering death?

CUSTOMER: Yes.

DMV LADY: *(Types into computer; looks)* Well, you're not on the computer.

CUSTOMER: I told you I wasn't.

DMV LADY: Fine. I will give you an award at the end of the day. How else may I help you?

CUSTOMER: I . . . I would like to get my permanent license.

DMV LADY: I'm sorry. There is no record of you on the computer.

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CUSTOMER: Yes, but I have my temporary license. *(Hands it to her)*

DMV LADY: This temporary license has expired.

CUSTOMER: Yes, I know it's expired.

DMV LADY: It is no longer a valid license.

CUSTOMER: I know that. That's why I want my permanent one. I hadn't noticed it hadn't come in the mail until this one had already expired. I had presumed everything was alright.

DMV LADY: What a funny thing to do. *(Suspicious)* If you do not have a valid driver's license, how did you get here to the Division of Motor Vehicles?

CUSTOMER: I took a taxi.

DMV LADY: Can you prove that to me?

CUSTOMER: What?

DMV LADY: Did you keep a receipt from the taxi?

CUSTOMER: No, I didn't.

DMV LADY: I trust you did not drive here yourself, did you, Mr. James Agnes?

CUSTOMER: No, no, I realize my license is not valid.

DMV LADY: That is correct. You have an invalid license. Good morning.

CUSTOMER: But you're not helping me.

DMV LADY: *(Pleasantly)* How may I help you?

CUSTOMER: I want my driver's license.

DMV LADY: You must take the driving test.

CUSTOMER: But I took the driving test.

DMV LADY: I have no record of that.

CUSTOMER: I know you have no record of it, some *schmuck* lost it in the computer . . .

DMV LADY: Kindly do not speak Yiddish to me. If you wish to make an appointment to take the driving test, go to Window 4. *(Goes back to reading).*

CUSTOMER: I DON'T WANT TO TAKE THE TEST AGAIN!

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DMV LADY: *(Irritated)* Well, when did you take the test before?

CUSTOMER: It's the same date as that on my temporary license.

DMV LADY: February 3, 1894. The Division of Motor Vehicles did not exist in 1894.

CUSTOMER: Let me see that. *(Looks)* Alright, it's a type. It's clearly meant to be 1994.

DMV LADY: I am willing to agree with you that it is more likely a typo. You see, I don't stick to the rules on everything. I am human. What is your name again?

CUSTOMER: James Agnes.

DMV LADY: Is that a as in aardvark, g as in gesundheit . . . .

CUSTOMER: James Agnes!

DMV LADY: Let me see if we have a record of you in the computer *(Types into computer)*

CUSTOMER: You don't, you don't, I told you you don't!

DMV LADY: Why are you shouting at me? When I am shouted at, I do not feel like cooperating.

CUSTOMER: But you haven't *been* cooperating.

DMV LADY: I have been cooperating. If I had not been cooperating, you would have been shouting at me much earlier than this.

CUSTOMER: I want my license.

DMV LADY: Well, you can't have it. You're not on the computer.

CUSTOMER: But that's not my fault.

DMV LADY: And it's not my fault. We are both blameless. Isn't it a nice feeling?

CUSTOMER: You are not helping me.

DMV LADY: I am doing everything in my power.

CUSTOMER: But don't you have more power than you're using? Can't you for instance, type me into the computer, and then send me my license?

DMV LADY: No. Only the secretary at the driving test site can do that.

CUSTOMER: But when she forgets to do that at the time of the driving test, can't someone else do it then?

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DMV LADY: If the secretary at the driving test site is willing to write a note admitting that she had forgotten to type in your name, then I can enter your name into the computer. And then we will fire her. Do you want her to lose her job?

CUSTOMER: No I don't. I want you to lose *your* job.

DMV LADY: I don't see how you can expect me to help you if you're going to be hostile.

CUSTOMER: Isn't there anything you can suggest to solve my problem?

DMV LADY: *(Thinks)* If you could re-live the initial driving test, when it was finished, you could ask to watch the secretary type in your name and your test result into the computer.

CUSTOMER: Your suggestion is that I *re-live* the initial driving test?

DMV LADY: It is a hypothetical suggestion, I admit, but it is the limit of what I can think of to assist you.

CUSTOMER: Could I see your supervisor, please?

DMV LADY: My supervisor is shredding documents in the other room, and cannot be disturbed.

CUSTOMER: *(Angry)* Look into my eyes. I want you to tell me what I should do that will solve my problem, and I want you to tell me *right now*!

DMV LADY: Move out of New York.

CUSTOMER: *(Taken aback, but it might be worth it).* That's a good suggestion. Thank you. (He storms out)

DMV LADY: *(Calling after him)* Ohio's nice. *(She goes back to reading)*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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